

~~REDACTED~~
Religion in Japan # 13

introduction

Japan has many of same characteristics as Chinese religion and culture, ie., socially oriented, isolationist, practical and this worldly. They have a strong historical awareness coupled with a sense of the unchanging essence of her people. these caractereistics have attained remarkable durability as a result of Japan's relative geographic isolation and racial homogeneity.

result is that Japanese native traditions and spirit have survived waves of foreign cultural inundation from China and the west.

Japanese folk religion as practiced in piety by the ordinary people, shares characteristics in common with other cultures in its this-worldly, communal, pragmatic, magical and adaptive features.

However, it also embodies a sense of the sacredness of the land and people nourished by its beauty and relative isolation and security. result, is strong racial sentiment which sees Japan in a central role in the cosmic order.

During the stone age what inhabitants there were, were of largely Ainu stock, whose religion involved blood sacrifice and the bear ritual. It seems to have had no influence on the invading Japanese who entered the four main islands from both the north and south.

The earliest records are the Kojiki (the record of

ancient things) written in C.E 712 in Chinese characters which are phonetically Japanese, and the Nihongi (Japanese chronicles) from 720 C.E. which gives a history of Japan up to 697.

Both works try to show that Japan has a divine mission upon earth and thus pass smoothly from myth to history and back presenting the merely mythological as tho it were verifiable history.

It is evident from Chinese documents that unification of Japan took 6 or 7 hundred years (till about the 8th cent, C.E.) and it would appear from these documents that authority lay with women rulers who acted as shamens or mediums, thus preserving in their person the unity of the regal (or political) and the priestly (or religious) function, which later became the emperor's role.

all freely accepted foreign cultural elements are transformed to bring them in harmony with Japanese views. This process is evident in the adoption by the Japanese of Confucian, Buddhist, and Taoist beliefs and practices and particularly of Christianity which has had great difficulty in gaining acceptance.

These various traditions have been fused into a complex whole.

Japanese perspective on religion

There are three angles with which to approach Japanese Religion: this worldly realism, communalism, and emphasis on

purity.

The Japanese throughout history have enjoyed life in this world. Their landscape and productive soil have inspired them to believe it is truly a land of the gods.

awareness of the goodness of the land stimulated all forms of art and efforts transform even the most lowly object into a thing of beauty. There has been a conscious attempt to harmonize man-made structures with their natural surroundings attesting to a sense of kinship and unity with Nature.

This sense of awe and wonder aroused by the creative forces of Nature has also provided the basis for accompanying traits of pragmatism, eclecticism, tolerance, and a more intuitive, sentimental and nonintellectual approach to religion among the Japanese.

They believed that gods and spirits inhabited natural objects. Their openness to nature and phenomena also meant an openness to influences from the rest of the world. They not only welcomed Chinese culture with its religious beliefs and practices but they continued the transformation of other-worldly Buddhism which had begun in China. They were receptive to claims that buddhism possessed superior magic powers for dealing with divine forces as seen in the sometimes erratic behaviour of nature.

The intuitive approach has expressed itself in the widespread Japanese sentiment that Buddhism and religion in general is mysterious and profound. Concern for the mood

and beauty of a ritual outweighs in significance any intellectual consideration in its evaluation. Group sentiment has played a great role in determining thought.

Illustration of predominance of intuition over intellectualization is the contrast in the ways of understanding the nature of divinity in Japanese and western thought.

in west philosophers and theologians attempt to define what God is; then they seek the evidences of his existence in the world.

the Japanese regard the impressions of beauty, mystery, awe, goodness, or ugliness which arise in encounters with things in the world as signs of the presence of divinity within those things.

thus, the idea of divinity begins with the recognition of the special character of the object which points beyond itself to a more fundamental reality behind and within.

there is no need to define or prove divinity in this context as in the Western mode of thinking, because the recognition of the peculiar significance of the object constitutes its quality of divinity.

Divinity is not limited to a specific class of objects nor to one set of attributes. Aesthetically, this perspective encourages art and the exaltation of the common and menial.

communalism

Began with primary commitment to the clan and family in ancient times. Eventually this commitment extended to the central imperial clan which gradually grew more powerful as the government transformed into a centralized bureaucratic state on the Chinese model. Supported by similar Confucian principles, the Japanese came to view their country as a great family headed by the imperial parent.

Thus religion throughout Japanese history has been inextricably interwoven with kinship, group, and national concerns and relationships.

On the village level the Dozoku kinship unit (a group of related, nuclear families in hierarchical arrangement involving status and obligations) has been the major religious unit. Religious festivals generate a cohesive spirit as all the members strive to secure the life of the group thru ceremonies designed to stimulate fertility or pacify the spirits of the dead. The centrality of the kinship group was expressed in ancestor reverence, which has been an essential feature in every tradition, native or foreign.

significant implication is that the group has priority over the individual in all vital social matters. ones religion and religious activity depends on his groups obligations thus religious commitment and belief have not been emphasized.

The Emperor came to symbolize the unity of the people as the supreme mediator between the gods and the people. he

was the concrete expression of the divinity of the nation being a direct descendant of the Sun Goddess, Amaterasu-O-Mikami, the kami (see below) of the Yamato clan.

loyalty to the emperor came ahead of loyalty to family as in China.

This concept of Kokutai (national essence) provided the ideology of modern Japanese nationalism.

Emperor reverence relates to the tendency to form strong bonds of devotion to concrete individuals, whether emperor, Lord, or teacher. This characteristic contributed to factionalism and sectarianism in later developments of Japanese Buddhism.

concern for purity

Japanese emphasis on purity initially centered on the avoidance of actions giving rise to physical or ritual pollution or uncleanness which could threaten the well-being of the community and the individual. In common with other lesser developed peoples, the early Japanese focused their attention on the external, concrete act. Eventually consideration was given to motivation and inner character.

Japanese concern for purification was early observed by the Chinese. a central ceremony was the Oharae whose text is contained in the Norito (ritual prayers). From this we can understand what their idea of sin or pollution was.

According to the prayer, sins were divided into heavenly and earthly.

the heavenly sins were:

Breaking down the ridges, covering up the ditches,
Releasing the irrigation sluices, Double planting, Setting
up stakes, Skinning alive, skinning backwards,
Defecation--Many sins (such as these) are distinguished and
called the heavenly sins.

The earthly sins were:

Cutting living flesh, cutting dead flesh, White
leprosy, skin excrescences, The sin of violating one's own
mother, one's own child, a mother and her child, a child and
he mother, the sin of transgression with animals, Woes from
creeping insects, Woes from the birds of on high, Woes from
the deities of on high, killing animals, the sin of
witchcraft--many sins (such as these) shall appear.

The performance of the rite of purification caused the gods
to take away all the sins recounted above.

According to the ritual, the Goddess Se-ori-tu-hime who
dwelled in the fast-flowing rivers carried the sins to the
ocean where they were swallowed by the Goddess
Haya-aki-tu-hime. When she swallowed them at a gulp, the
deity Ibuki-do then blew them all to the underworld and
tranquility reigned.

As can be seen, sins were primarily social in character.
Good and evil were completely distinguished according to
whether an act was beneficial for the community or

dangerous.

The term good (yoshi) covered a wide area such as beauty, excellence, good fortune, and nobility. Bad (ashi) signified something evil-omened, inferior, and unlucky. In mythology, the polarization of good and evil was expressed in Magatsubi-no-kami (bending Kami) and the Naobi-no-kami (straightening Kami). The former were gods of pollution and disaster, while the latter were those who restored things to a normal condition.

then part of Shinto
Tho early Shinto possessed awareness of purity and pollution (good and evil) it did not have a formal value system. rather, it sought unity with the Kami in each action. To attain unity with the Kami meant to cultivate a bright, pure, correct and straight mind.

Tho the Japanese concern for purity became more inward, it was not guilt ridden nor ascetic since it believed in the essential goodness of man and was optimistic.

Many imperial edicts stressed purity of heart or the honest sincere heart. one must have pure intention in fulfilling vows.

Among the symbols of imperial authority, the mirror represented the pure heart as interpreted by the Shinto thinker Kitabatake Chikafusa:

The Mirror harbors nothing within itself. As it reflects all phenomena without a selfish heart, there is never an instance when the forms of right and wrong, or good and evil fail to show up. Its virtue consists in responding to these forms as they come. This is the basic source of

correctness and uprightness.

In addition to the ideals of purity of body and spirit the principles of filial piety, loyalty, gratitude, and sincerity have been key elements in Japanese moral existence.

a keen sense of duty and obligation has inspired them with serious purpose. These fundamental social values have received support and reinforcement from the religious traditions. Confucianism (especially the principle of li or propriety) strengthened Japanese moral sentiments and provided the theoretical structure for native morality.

The Japanese have developed a highly ceremonial and ritualistic culture.

The Japanese religious perspective harmonized well with religio-philosophical elements imported from China. Confucianism implemented moral and political tendencies thru affirming hierarchy, authority, monarchy, filial piety, and duty.

Religious Taoism amplified magical techniques and divination practices

Buddhism expanded the scope of the Japanese understanding of human life and offered gorgeous imagery, ceremony, and pageantry appealing to the Japanese aesthetic sentiment.

Religion in Japanese History

The indigenous Japanese religion coming from prehistoric times faced the subtle complexity and pageantry of Mahayana

buddhism which appealed to many facets of Japanese character

rather than fading from history the two religions merged on the folk level, and the native tradition became more self-conscious thru the compilation of its myths in the two above mentioned books. Borrowing Chinese terminology, the native tradition came to be known as Shinto (the Way of the Gods.)

Despite the formalization of Shinto, buddhist perspectives and activity dominated the Japanese religious world on the institutional and intellectual levels.

however, the national sentiment, grounded in Shinto faith in the divinity of the rulers and the country, never permitted leaders to neglect their obligations to the gods of the people.

On the surface the foreign culture appeared stronger, but the folk sentiment nourished the roots as an underground stream and the foreign tradition transformed into the national image.

Thus, because of national sentiment and Buddhist tolerance, Shinto ritual and outlook on life persevered.

during the 12th to 14th century and later in the 17th to 19th cent. shinto tradition became re-awakened alongside the flourishing of numerous popular, lay-oriented Buddhist sects.

Associations of exponents of pure Shinto w/o foreign accretions began to appear one after another to lay the

foundations for the restoration of the Emperor to political authority.

The modern political use of Shinto as the basis of Japanese nationalism depended on the latent sentiments in the minds of the people. Modern popular religious cults have drawn upon either Shinto or Buddhist traditions, taking advantage of the deep-rooted association of these traditions in the hearts of the people.

Despite tension in modern times, the two traditions complement each other.

Buddhism with its universal, cosmic philosophy provides a vision of Japan as the kingdom of Buddha radiating buddhist wisdom and compassion to the world.

Shinto supports that sense of uniqueness and particularity in the Japanese which has prevented them from losing their identity in the midst of floods of foreign influence.

SHINTO

As with other ancient societies, the early Japanese were concerned with securing food and maintaining the continuity of the group. As a means to achieve these ends, the Japanese early came to revere mountains. there were three types of belief concerning their sacredness. Conically shaped dormant volcanoes, supremely represented by Mount Fuji, have been objects of reverence. Mountains have also

been associated with fertility as the sources of water. They have also been conceived as either residences of the dead or the way the dead ascend to heaven.

the outstanding feature of the religion was a female shaman, Himeko, sun daughter), who acted to bring peace and order to the community after protracted strife. Her activity may have provided the model for the myth of the central female Sun Goddess, Amaterasu-o-Mikami.

Ancestor worship and concern for the spirits of the dead became especiall prominent from the 8th to the 12th cent. because all social and personal crises such as political changes, civil war, epidemics, famines, droughts, earthquakes, etc. were believed to be the result of revenge by the angry spirits of the dead. Sometimes they were believed to be caused by the angry or jealous souls of living men and women.

these beliefs still persist to the present time and ceremonies must be held to pacify spirits of people who have suffered untimely death.

the Origin of these beliefs is rooted in several things. The shaman possessed by a diety, deification of nobles after death, belief in spirits and the equality of all people that Buddhist and taoist belief brought into their religion. In Buddhism the belief attained its strongest expression as it was originally not central to Shinto.

shamanism has never been institutionalized but has persisted to the present, appearing even in contemporary

religions. It has combined with alien traditions of buddhism and Taoism.

most are female, tho some^{male} shamans are present. The emperor possessed shamanic charisma thru his descent from the sun goddess and as head of the imperial clan.

forms of shinto

shrine shinto the term is a relatively modern one and refers to what was supported by the state in its efforts to provide a basis for national integration and feeling.

sect shinto refers to individually founded modern religious orders based on shinto beliefs and practices.

Folk Shinto is applied to the magico-religious beliefs which are the substratum of beliefs and sentiment in all other aspects of Shinto. it serves both individual and communal purposes. the individual attempts to satisfy his various needs for health, wealth, and security in life, while the communal cult is the focus for harmonization of the local society, politically and culturally.

imperial house shinto refers specifically to those rites carried out by the Emperor and his family.

domestic shinto signifies the worship centered on the god-shelf in the ordinary homes.

Although Buddhism as well as Shinto have been associated on the folk level it is shinto which, thru all changes, has continued to provide the foundation of the Japanese

religious consciousness as a sacred people in a sacred land.

Shinto has evolved into a complex system paralleling the transformation of the people from a group of clans to a modern industrial state.

Kami: myth and ritual in traditional shinto

Materials from the Kojiki and Nihongi are the main source for these myths and material. tho these are the product of a specific class of people.

Shinto was not consciously cultivated in early times nor systematically organized. It was rather the awe of the suprahuman powers in nature that penetrates all areas of religion and is the basis of their conception of deity.

The central core of Shinto lies in its peculiar awareness of divinity which points in the direction of a conception similar to the Polynesians mixed with the more pantheistic tendencies of Buddhism and Taoism.

kami in Shinto does not refer to an absolute being who stands distinct from the world but refers more to a quality in things, persons, and forces, whether good or evil, which raises them above the ordinary level of evaluation thru the sense of awe, wonder, fear, attraction, or repulsion which the object arouses in the person.

The Shinto scholar Motoori Norinaga (1730-1801) gives the clearest definition:

It may be said that Kami signifies, in the first place, the deities of heaven and earth that appear in the ancient records and also the spirits of the shrines where they are

worshipped.

It is hardly necessary to say that it includes human beings. It also includes such objects as birds, beasts, trees, plants, seas, mountains, and so forth. In ancient usage, anything whatsoever which was outside the ordinary, which possessed superior power or which was awe-inspiring was called kami. among human beings who are called kami the successive generations of sacred emperors are all included.

Dragons, echoes, foxes, tigers, wolves, peaches, rocks, stumps, leaves and thunder are also included in nonhuman kami.

Since divinity (kami) permeate the whole cosmos there is no division between secular and sacred existence.

there were considered to be eight hundred myriads of deities (8,000,000). this conception had the sense of the abundance and pervasiveness of divine power thru the whole cosmos and life.

as one scholar of Japanese religion points out this is polytheism but not 'idolatry'. he says:

Life, by its very nature, tends to be infinite. Historians of religion, by penetrating the more profoundly into the religious reality, have come to recognize that former generations have misjudged polytheism. What they understood to be "idolatry," was never practised in this manner by any religion. Religious people, by worshipping a variety of objects, always intended one thing, the SACRED, which they expressed in many forms.

As the society developed, the originally unorganized cult took firmer shape with more concrete conceptions of deity, formation of priestly functionaries, and establishment of shrines and rituals.

Classifications also appeared in the types of spirits recognized in Shinto: Traditionally, Shinto acknowledged four kinds of spirits, 1. those which rule with authority

and power, 2. those which bring about union, harmony, and recollection, 3. those which cause mysterious transformation, and 4. those which impart blessings.

One and the same kami might have more than one function. Spirits of enemies and those who might have met an unfortunate death were also believed to have power. spirits of animals could also function and were feared and venerated. People could be possessed by the kami.

four classes of functionaries appeared in shinto. these were ritualists, abstainers, diviners and musicians and dancers. ~~as early as 8th cent. C.E. control of the~~

~~cultic practice~~

~~Festivals represented the people's active response to environmental changes in the quest for food and group survival. Many were thus seasonal praying for good crops (Feb. 4), a harvest festival (Nov. 23-24) and a local shrine festival. the purpose of the festivals were:~~

~~to ward off any misfortune and secure or augment the cooperation of the kami in promoting the happiness and peace of the individual and community. They include prayer for divine protection, communion with the kami, praise of the kami's virtue, comfort for the kami's mind, reports to the kami on the affairs of daily life, and pledges offering the whole life to the kami.~~

~~There are more than 80,000 shrines of varying status.~~

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ethics the central ethical concept is that of on. because of the awareness of the goodness of nature there is the obligation one has to his benefactor and the gratitude which expresses it.

the idea that life wins out over death and pollution is important to their concept of purity. there is affirmation of the life force which becomes embodied in history thru man's work and effort.

another important theme drawn from the mythical tradition was the principle of saisei-itchi (union of government and religion). this forms the basis of the

self-understanding of the nation. This concept teaches that the religious and political dimensions of life are essentially one.

Commitment to the nation is an ultimate commitment and has manifested itself in modern times in extremes of patriotic sentiment, for example, the Kamikaze pilots of WW II.

This principle has had to be set aside as a result of the Sinto directive issued in 1945 declaring absolute separation of church and state in Japan. Despite the abuses of the concept in modern times, it does hold the ideal that human society is not only an organized secular arrangement, but a spiritual reality in which mundane and divine affairs are completely integrated and harmonious.

struggle for pure shinto

with the coming of Buddhist, taoist and Confucian thought there were accomodations made over the centuries. However, there were attempts to weed-out all non-shinto ideas starting in the 13th cent. c.e. The reason for this self-conscious Shinto polemic and apologetic may stem from what was believed to be remarkable interventions of the gods saving Japan from the Mongol invasions in 1274 and 1281 thru great winds (kamikaze)

Shinto religion flourished in times of danger when the rulers called on the national deities to aid the nation.

The most important development for the evolution of

Shinto thought was the emergence of the National Learning school which aimed at reawakening and purifying the national consciousness based in Shinto against Buddhist, Confucian, or Christian influences which had penetrated Japanese culture.

its patriotic fervor sets the stage for the modern employment of Shinto as the ideological basis for nationalism and national cohesion.

There were several important thinkers but two in particular were key figures in the background of modern Shinto thought and scholarship. These are as follows: Motoori Norinaga (1730-1801) already quoted above, brought the school to its highest development in purging Japanese and Shinto thought from its Confucian and Buddhist influences. He used linguistic study to interpret the Kojiki and Nihongi in depth.

Using particularly the Kojiki he showed the basis for cultivating spiritual sentiment in adoration of the Sun Goddess and the elevation of two other deities that were strictly Japanese as symbols of the life force.

He gave expression in a telling fashion to the intuitive, emotional side of the Japanese spirit in his attempt to displace the dominant Confucian rationalism.

He asserted the superiority of Japan over other nations, pointing to the unbroken line of emperors as witness. He suggested a messianic destiny for Japan because she possessed the ancient way of the Sun Goddess.

According to him, truth lay in the expression of human feeling and sentiment and he felt Buddhist monasticism was against man's nature and thus insincere. The primary value for Norinaga was sincerity (magrokorō):

Those who boast
That they cannot be moved--
Are they made of stone and wood?

To veil and hide
the Sincere Heart,
To put on airs
to pretend--
Such are the ways of China.

Hirata Atsutane (1776-1843)

more intellectual. a physician, he had gained his notions of creation and eschatology from Christian sources. However, he was committed to the revival of Shinto and hated all things foreign. all his knowledge was permeated and woven together by his exaltation of Shinto as the highest knowledge.

Tho despising the West, he appreciated the value of Western science and the influence of Christian thought was evident in his concept of deity and afterlife.

Deities of Shinto were universal gods and he used evidences from other religions concerning the existence of a supreme creator to support his contention of the truth of Shinto teaching.

He took great comfort in advocating his position from the Copernican revolution which recognized that the world revolved around the sun saying the Japanese had always

recognized this.

He saw the world as a place of testing, and all accounts would be squared in the world of souls.

Ult. concern for both of these thinkers was to define and promote Shinto (shinto is that which is against Buddhism). had to eliminate everything foreign and get back to original Shinto.

highest reality was their Kamis, especially Amaterasu-o-Mikami, the sun goddess, Ame-no-mi-naka-nushi-no-kami who was the highest personified deity. considered Taka-mi-mushubi-no-kami as the creator of all.

human predicament was caused by not recognizing the "true way" (shinto) of the Kamis. thus we suffer. solution follow the true way.

Shinto and patriotism

Most significant outcome of the national learning movement was the restoration of Imperial authority under the emperor in 1868 and the establishment of Shinto as the official ideology and expression of patriotism.

Japanese leaders responsible for preparing Japan to take its position in the modern world politically and industrially sought in Shinto the basis of national cohesion.

Shinto was proclaimed the state religion, and Buddhism

was purged from any association with Shinto shrines and ceremonies. The anti-foreign feelings led to many temples being burned with the slogan "abolish Buddha, cut down Sakyamuni (icons).

A board was set up of Shinto Missionaries to propagandize and indoctrinate the people concerning shinto and patriotism. It aimed to check the spread of Christianity. There were three main points.

1. compliance with the spirit of reverence for Kami and love of country;
2. Clarification of "the principle of Heaven and the Way of man",
3. Exalting the emperor and obeying the Imperial Court.

The effort was a history of failure for several reasons and the whole thing was abandoned in 1882.

It was impossible to weed-out all foreign thought since it was already so ingrained. Also, there was far more sectarianism within Shinto than had been thought. Progressives and conservatives couldn't agree. It was argued that there must be separation of church and state in a modern nation.

With defeat in WW II, the new Constitution made it explicit that the government must henceforth refrain from any religious involvements.

The problems of Shinto within the modern development of Japan have raised the question of whether shinto is a religion or merely a patriotic cult. Both views are present

in modern Japan.

New Religions

There have been many explicitly religious movements inspired by charismatic individuals and based on Shinto beliefs and outlook since ~~the~~ the turn of the 19th cent. and another wave since WW II. These have been termed the "new religions."

These have had phenomenal growth especially when compared to the political movements such as communism.

These religious mass movements are a combination of ancient and modern themes. There are five common factors which have led to the appearance of these sects.

1. social crisis, or upheaval in the cultural situation
2. A charismatic leader or inspired personality.
3. performance of miracles and wonders;
4. forms of ecstatic behavior as trance; and
5. syncretic doctrines.

In contrast to the highly intellectual, alien, and radical pronouncements of political mass movements which are out of touch with the feelings of the majority of people, the "New Religions" have been very successful in concentrating attention on the concrete need of the people for health, wealth, and security in the highly competitive mass society.

A major appeal of most groups is the promise of benefits thru magical practices and faith.

They cater to the need of individuals for recognition and status thru offering means of mobility within the

organization for ordinary people of devotion and zeal.

These sects fall into five categories

1. pure shinto so called because they worship deities central to ancient Shinto tradition and are devoted to the ideals of Shinto.

2. Confucian sects also follow the basic tenets of Shinto, but are buttressed with teachings with moral and social concepts derived from Confucian tradition.

3. mountain sects (three in number) are based on traditional Japanese reverence for mountains. Two worship Mt. Fuji and one Mt. Ontake. Their aim is the security and prosperity of the nation.

4. Purification sects (two) emphasized ritualism as the means to attain the goals of national, individual and human existence. Particularly, they support the practices of ancient Shinto.

5. Faith-healing groups which stress material and bodily welfare thru cultivating the spirit.

The Tenri-kyo and Omoto-kyo sects were founded by women who had a prophetic revelation in which a new age was foretold with the paradisiac condition of the age of the kami.

The sect shinto religious organizations have maintained their existence down to the present time. Some have split into sub groups so that they now total about 75 groups with Tenri-kyo the most active of all.

a survey of the Shinto tradition reveals that the ancient religion had a durability and vitality thru the ages and has provided spiritual orientation in the face of crisis on the intellectual level as well as popular level.

In the present, Shinto has suffered from the defeat of WW II, but as a whole it was more than a cult of nationalism.

it is bein reinterpreted to povide a philosophy of life adequate to attract modern intellectuals.

It has also displayed great potentiality as a resource for the emergence of new religious communities, which could orient men and women in a difficult world and constantly renew their sense of being a sacred people in a sacred land.

Tenriko

Mentioned last time, but will give more detail since it is the largest of the newer religions (other than Soka Gakki)

Nakayama a woman founded it in 1838 when she had a revelation from the God Tenri, who is their highest reality.

They have about 2,000,000 adherents with a large headquarters, school and sanctuary dedicated to Tenri. They have their own city called Tenri city.

the faithful believe they stand at the center of the universe.

followers are taught that the deity possessed Nakayama and she was transfigured by the god (the deity of divine reason).

they considered her body a shrine for the god.

teaches: physical as well as mental and spiritual sickness in the world is caused by hokori "dusts"--all these dusts cause suffering by making the spirit unclean. these are:

1. covetousness, 2. stinginess, 3. misdirected love, 4. hatred, 5. revenge, 6. anger, 7. arrogance, 8. selfishness (this is the worst and the root of all the others.)

human predicament is suffering and sorrow in the world caused by bad attitudes (dusts). The fact of the world is that the soul of man is part of the omnipresent deity, Tenri.

The body of human is temporarily loaned by Tenri along with all material things so wealth should be used to help our fellow man.

The dusts themselves may be swept away by exercise of sincere faith and surrender to the benevolence of Tenri and trust in Him.

Ul. concern is that in place of the 8 dusts arise the 8 satisfactions:

1. longevity, 2. freedom from sickness, 3. harmonious and peaceful adjustments to all situations, 4. successful accomplishments of undertakings, 5. prosperous descendents, 6. sufficiency of material things, 7. thankful spirit, 8. inner tranquility.

They practice faith healing with the prayer: "sweep away evil and save us thou wonderful King of divine reason."

they uphold the dignity of labor--virtue of unrequited service to others. thankfulness to fellowmen to be able to serve them.

ultimate goal is to change the whole world by changing individuals. bring back age of kamis.

If you don't experience joy in life its because you don't realize the meaning--to live for Tenri--must dust your mind of the 8 things.

to summarize:

Ul. Con- 8 satisfactions, spreading this universally to bring back age of Kami.

H. R.-Tenri, souls all part of Tenri

Hum. Pred.-death, suffering, etc. caused by the 8 dusts

which reduce to selfishness.

Solution- practice of sincere faith, unrequited service
and worship.

SKP

MYTHOS

comes from the Greek and has the classical meaning of a "religious pattern of world-orientation."

however, myth is not solely found in the religious context but as a living part of all vital cultural patterns.

Secular mythos is a recent thing but the "American dream", consisting of mother's apple pie and the four freedoms are part of it

an instance of consciously created mythos is that of Nazi Germany with the key concept being the superiority of the Aryan race and the transcendental good and mighty destiny of the German nation.

The basic significance of all living myth forms lies in their power to relate men effectively to each other and to human historical existence in some actionable manner, their capacity to give men a sense of identity and destiny sufficient to move them to deeds.

The first function of a mythos is that of rational explanation of the mysteries surrounding human experience.

In this sense the only difference between the primitive and the modern man is one of the varying location of these limits.

Because the limits are so much "farther out" for contemporary man, there is currently little enthusiasm for any type of ultimate explanations especially those in answer

to "Why"?

The second and most fundamental function of mythos in general and religious mythos in particular may be stated thus:

Mythos is a mode of action. It is man's way of relating himself existentially to the basic realities or the totality of his environmental condition.

ie, the mythical is the form par excellence by which religious awareness seeks to grasp the world and its actionable significance for man.

humankind is concerned to relate themselves as a unity to the cosmos as a unity on the most fundamental existential level as the context for all creative action. To this end they create religious mythos of which all lesser linguistic and cultural myths are but pale reflections and minor imitations.

culturally determined mythos patterns are of prime importance in the way a society looks at reality.

the historical-linear sense of time, in which historical development follows a nonrepetitive movement on into the future has been extremely important in the west.

it is a denial of the cyclic mythos of the east, in which there is no ultimate goal in history.

it results in the assertion of the unique importance of each passing nonrepeatable event as a time of decision for the making of the future.

this mythos has been the continuing source of Western social and political dynamism-even in its sometimes demonic and perverted forms. (Nazism).

~~practices of the Aborigines~~

SOME EXTINCT EXAMPLES OF ARCHAIC RELIGIONS

Aztecs and Mayas

Both Aztec and Maya distinguish between "ancient" gods and "younger" gods. The god of fire is invariably an ancient god as is the god of merchants, probably because the ancestors of these merchants belonged to an indigenous population group.

With the Maya the original nature and agrarian deities were the ancient gods, whereas the gods they adopted from the Toltecs, like Quetzalcoatl (plumed serpent), were younger ones, who were more involved in the cosmic and socio-cultural aspects of their society.

In the religious as well as social concept of the universe held by all Central American peoples there were direct associations between space, time and color, which have similar structures, but show slight variations from people to people.

Taking earth as the centre, they distinguished six cosmic directions: The four quarters of space, above (heaven) and below (the underworld). So inclusive of the center (the earth), there were seven divisions in cosmic space.

Each religious and social system in central America is found to have an order that is a complicated elaboration of this system of four horizontal directions and the three vertical directions (the 3 cosmic layers).

this principle was connected with a dualistic world view based on the man -woman opposition.

their organizational groups of deities, chiefs, priests, military leaders and other dignataries were arranged in 3's or 4's to coincide with there cosmological views.

Each horizontal direction was associated with different colors.

The combination of space and color was associated with time, and time was closely connected with the gods, especially among the Maya.

The universe and consequently life on earth was successively controlled by a particular combination of direction, time, and gods.

The Toltecs and Aztecs called the cosmic ages determined in this way "suns". This concept also existed among the Maya, and like the Toltecs they distinguished four such cosmic ages, each determined by one of the quarters and the gods belonging to it.

These existed both simultaneously and in sequence since time to them was a relative concept. Each "sun" was dominated by one particular combination, which after a certain length of time had to surrender its ascendancy to another combination.

The Toltecs, Aztecs, and Maya divided heaven into thirteen parts, adding one step to the pyramid of heaven by subdividing the older topmost heaven of the Maya and Olmecs into five heavens.

Every Human has a counterpart

a fundamental conception in Central American thinking is the existence of so-called 'counterparts in disguise'.

every human being was thought to have one or more 'counterparts', mostly disguised as animals, whose fates were linked to that of the human being in a manner conditioned by cosmic forces.

The day was divided into 13 periods, each ruled by one of the gods, while the night had 9 periods while the sun passed thru the 9 spheres of the underworld.

Every human possessed from the moment of birth a personal combination of these periods, which to a great extent determined his or her fate. This was shared with an animal counterpart. This used to be and still is the principle underlying many acts of magic in this cultural area.

by doing harm to or destroying a counterpart one can kill or make a person ill. By strengthening a sick person's animal counterpart one cures him or her.

History is divided into 5 suns in which evolution of life took place. catastrophy could interfere. Within each sun only those forms of earthly life could flourish that were

organized according to the principles governing the order at that time.

the relation between people and their gods were governed by the principle of reciprocity.

People were obliged to feed and strengthen their gods. The extreme consequence of this being the human sacrifices, which were constantly performed by the Aztecs.

Before the 11th century the Aztec tribe united with the tribe of Mexitin into one religious, social and administrative organization. The less civilized Mexitin tribe eventually gained control of the religious system.

The political as well as religious ambitions of the Aztec-Mexica implied the control or at least the regulation of war as an instrument to gain and exercise power, and the unification of all the peoples on earth into one social, religious and administrative organization to guarantee the harmonious preservation of the human race.

The Aztec-Mexica people considered themselves to be in charge of the regulation of all earthly matters during the fifth cosmic age.

They were highly tolerant in religious and cultural matters.

A system of ritual battles with a limited number of warriors fighting on pre-determined battlefields became the standard way of waging war.

The main religious purpose was the captureing of

prisoners of war who could at some later time be sacrificed to one or more deities.

The social purpose was to enable the sons of noble families, officers and brave warriors of low descent to win honor and fame and thus rise on the social ladder.

Ideologically, wars of flowers might be regarded as an attempt to prevent decadence.

Pantheon

highest god was Tezcatlepecca (it causes the black mirror to shine, the god of the nocturnal sky) was considered a real teotl, that is permanent, powerful. It lived everywhere, in hell, on earth and in heaven. pantheistic concept of the supreme god. he or it appears in more forms than any other god and under more names than any other.

The unique thing about their concept of divinity is the association of particular gods with particular social groups within a nation, or with entire tribes or nations.

One of the fundamentals of the Aztec concepts of divinity and religion in general was the cosmic interrelationship between all phenomena.

the Aztecs considered the supra-individual unity of a group of far greater importance than most Europeans do.

The cosmic relationship embodied in the constellation of the gods belonging to the 5th sun gave every individual

person as well as every group of persons is on her own predestined fate.

Considerable differences existed between the gods. But all Aztec deities had this in common, that they existed longer than man, for they were thought to exist in any case as long as the constellation of the fifth Sun. Since their existence was comparatively permanent, they were all gods.

Sacrifice

Every person in every class in the Aztec society sacrificed some of his own blood to one or more of the gods, usually piercing tongue or earlobes with a reed, causing considerable suffering.

Those in high positions often brought valuable offerings as well. Military conquerors offered their war captives. Their hearts were torn out by the priests and offered, still beating, to the god.

Every 20 days, ie 18 times a year, great religious festivals were held. Each social group brought offerings. The nation that brought the largest number of human offerings enjoyed the greatest prestige.

Three fundamental principles of Aztec ideology

The special duty to be fulfilled Huitzilopochtli, the chief god during the 5th sun, and his followers.

the readiness to participate in the wars of the flowers and/or to bring ritual offerings and do penance for the

purpose of preventing decadence.

the principle of reciprocity in the relations between the people and the gods.

Aztec youth, both male and female, were indoctrinated with these principles and other values in school from their 7th to there 20th year.

Schools were run by priests at scientific-religious boarding schools, or by army officers at the less strict military and vocational schools.

besides aztec dogma, they were taught to think and works left of pupils are evidence of this.

the need for sacrifice made the aztec religion a harsh one, but it was also a source of order and discipline within the society.

MAYA

The concept of Time was the center of Maya religious interest.

they are more metaphysical in nature than the Aztec religion

the "animal counterparts" played a far more important part and each "animal counterpart" was assumed to be connected with a thirteenfold "soul" which was shared by the animal and the person whose counterpart it was.

The present Nahua as well as Maya tribes have lost most of the intricate arrangement of the gods of heaven.

But the ancient nature gods, the sun-god and the rain-god, the goddess of the earth and the maize-gods, still play a major part in the daily life of the tribes sometimes in the disguise of Christian saints.

the ancient concepts of 'animal counterparts' has been preserved nearly everywhere, and the acts of magic are still being performed within the framework of these concepts.

Mayan calendar

based on the same principle as the Aztec but was even more important to the Mayans.

Like the Aztecs, the Maya reckoned with the ritual time unit of 260 days, divided into 13 x 20 days and called tzolkin.

they regarded these days as 260 different pairs of combinations of the gods of the 13 numbers with 20 gods of the day-signs.

14 divinities were associated with the numbers 0 and 1-13.

the Maya, like the Aztec, has a solar year of 365 days divided into 18 periods of 20 days, plus five remaining days.

The Maya are the first people on earth known to have developed the concept of the number 0, many centuries before the Hindus.

every 52 years was a crucial time as the idea that the 5th sun might be destroyed was possible. at this time all

fires in the country had to be extinguished. Old furniture and other household implements, pottery, images of gods, etc. were replaced by new ones. At the moment the Pleiades rose above the mountain of Colhuacan new fire was made by the high priest upon the breast of a sacrificed victim and distributed among all the temples and homes in the country.

For the Maya the Katun, which was a period of 7,200 days was the most important time unit with regard to religious matters.

The Maya were continually correcting their calendar, with the result that theirs was the most accurate calendar ever developed.

Do only
if time

~~Primitive Religions around the world~~

Tribal Religions in India - & The Vedic period in India

Anthropological observation among those living primitive peoples who have never progressed beyond the hunting and gathering stage gives a good idea of the kind of religious ideas and practices which are compatible with the style of life of nomadic food-gatherers.

It has become evident that there is no human group, however primitive, which lacks all ideas of supernatural beings or entities. We can't discover how much their beliefs resemble concepts and practices of pre-historic times but it can be assumed that these tribes do preserve some of the features of archaic religious systems which crystallized at a time when humankind's whole economy was based on hunting and gathering.

Primitive tribes of forest nomads are found in peninsular India, The Andaman Islands, in Malaya, in Sumatra and the Philippines. In all these regions they are still maintaining their ethnic and cultural identity.

Deities of Indian Forest Nomads

Chenchus--a Dravidian-speaking tribe of jungle nomads in the Indian state of Andhra Pradesh.

They are familiar with farming but have chosen to remain in the forest and subsist on wild roots, hunting, etc.

principle social unit is a group of families possessing hereditary rights to a tract of land within which boundries they may hunt and collect food.

Their World view is based on the feeling of human dependence on invisible beings concieved in antropomorphic terms. this world of invisible beings and humans are part of the natural order. They don't know where all came from, but accept it as fact. Their attitude towards the gods is sober and free of emotional involvement.

The main deity is a female called Garelamaisama, who is closely linked with the chase and the collection of edible plants.

She has power over animals and is therefore important to hunting luck. Male animals alone were killed since it agered the goddess if females were killed.

If accidently one was the hunter had to ask forgiveness. She is given a peice of meat roasted by the hunter after success as an offering also. She is believed to influence human behaviour also and is invoked to keep people from quarreling.

Bhagavantarū the god of thunder and rain is another prominent deity.

Neither of these deities are thought to concern themselves with human morality.

The Chenchus idea of people's fate after death is vague and there is not a concept that what is done in this life

determines the next.

Besides these two deities, the Chenchus worship a number of minor deities associated with specific localities or clans. They are propitiated by offerings, but these acts of worship are emotionally neutral appeals to supernatural powers.

Unlike many of the more advanced tribes, the Chenchus are not haunted by a fear of evil spirits or anxious about the effects of black magic.

There are no priests or other religious experts. Any adult male can make offerings. It is a religion of extreme simplicity. Humans and gods are believed to operate within a single sphere, and every individual has direct and immediate access to deities who, tho invisible, appear to the Chenchus as part of the natural world.

Gond tribes

a population of some 3,000,000 strong exztending over the hill regions of Mahhya Pradesh and northern Andhra Pradesh.

more economically advanced they have developed religous patterns of great complexity and their relations with the supernatural world are channelled into elaborate ceremonies conducted by ritual specialists.

Unlike the Chenchus, they are involved in myths of origin and aiteology (the beginning) of things.

Myth and ritual are elaborately tied together. At each of the major annual feasts they recite the appropriate myths

or legends and thereby keep the tradition alive.

Bhagavan is the deity who resides over the world. has at times been equated with Shiva. Gods and people turn to him for advice and assistance in difficulties but communicates with mortals indirectly. He does not figure big in rituals or offerings.

clan deities the cult of which is central to Gond religion and includes the sacrifice of goats and sheep is their main worship.

most of these deities were once clan members who now are guardians of their original clan. Their nature is complicated. Most of them represent an amalgam of a female and a male figure, conceived of as mother and son yet afterwards often referred to as a single deity.

three ritual functionaries are responsible for the worship of each set of clan deities. This is done twice a year for several days each. Newly dead are introduced to the deities.

The cult of clan-deities is one side of Gond worship, the other is worship of local and village deities.

In every village there is a shrine of the village mother and a sanctuary of the village guardian represented by a pointed wooden post.

the Earth mother is worshipped by Gond farmers just before sowing and at the harvest. all the female deities are not benevolent as some threaten the village with smallpox and cholera. and have to be placated with animal

sacrifice.

No one except a member of the lineage of clan-priests may function at the rites in honour of the clan-deities, and the cult of village mother and village guardian is a prerogative which belongs exclusively to the lineage of the village founder.

Seers can be anybody, these are ones who fall into a trance and speak for the gods.

the soul-concepts of the Gonds and many other Middle Indian tribes are based on the belief that the impersonal life-substance (jiv) which animates a person from birth to death is different from the personality which continues to exist after death and joins the ancestors in the land of the dead. Bhagavan at death recalls the life substance and brings death. When recalled the jiv is added to a pool of such substances available for reincarnation.

The personality of the deceased survives after death in the form of a spirit referred to as sanal or literally the departed.

There is no connection between people's moral conduct in this life and their fate in the land of the dead. Nor do the gods concern themselves with human morality.

To the Gond, religion is not personal relationship by a system of rites and sacrifices by means of which a community achieves the integration of human actions with the influence of the gods and spirits.

The idea of a battle between good and evil forces is *foreign* to the Gond's view of the world.

Hinduism

First of all, Indians don't think of themselves as HINDUS, but rather by the god they have chosen to worship. ie, those who worship Vishnu (northern India) call them selves Vaishnavites while those who follow Shiva, Shaivites. The word "Hindu" was given to those along the Indus river by the Muslims in the 12th cent.

A great civilization was in the Indus valley as early as 2500 BC. They worshipped a mother goddess as well as other spirits.

In about 1500 BC the great influx of Indo-European speaking peoples began coming in from the Iranian Plateau, not only to India but Greece, the middle east, etc.

They brought with them a very patriarchal system, their own priesthood, and almost exclusively male deities. Because they had chariots and Iron technology, they were able to conquer the more civilized areas they invaded.

The Brahmins, or priestly caste established the caste system which still, tho illegal, exists today.

THE VEDAS are the first written scriptures in the world that we know of. the word means "knowledge" in Sanskrit, an Indo-European language, ie sacred knowledge.

Over a period of some 1000 years, from about 1400 to 300 BC various parts were written, becoming more mystical, and more pessimistic with the passage of time.

In the west, it is the Upanisads written from 600-300 BC that are best known. There were hundreds, but there are 10 or so that are principle ones.

From the early Vedas, where the problem was not a long enough life, wealth, health, etc. the Upanisads (which means to sit nearby devotedly) consider that ignorance is the problem and knowledge is the solution. That is, knowledge of the fact that

observances and activities or philosophical meditation as it implies divine grace.

Lower bhakti is imperfect because it is motivated by worldly concerns such as sickness or the desire for something. there are 81 degrees of lower bhakti listed.

higher bhakti is completely selfless and involves single-hearted attachment to God. It is not the result of human striving but of pure grace. It is not the means of liberation, it is liberation.

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There are approximately 15 million gods in India today but I want to talk about a few major bhakti groups which are the most popular.

KRISHNA BHAKTI

The origin of devotion to Krishna is not known but one of the two great epics of India the MAHABHARATA written between 400 BC and 400 AD makes him a human hero.

the BHAGAVAD GITA, written around 200 BC, which forms only a small part of the entire epic (which is 3 1/2 times the length of the Bible) presents Krishna as the Supreme God who, if made an object of devotion, will save humans.

The Gita takes place on the battlefield where Krishna is a chariot driver for Arjuna. Arjuna is not happy about killing people who are related in this war but Krishna teaches that this is inevitable and that action or DHARMA done in a non attached manner, without concern for the fruits of the action, is the most adequate path to liberation. Those who die will be reborn.

in the climax of the Gita, chap. 11 Krishna reveals himself to Arjuna as the Lord of all and that devotion to him will save one from samsara. Krishna is the support of Brahman in the Gita

QUALIFIED NON-DUAL is the view of the gita, ie, it sees god as both personal and impersonal, beyond all distinctions of that

our soul (atman) is identical with the one absolute, Brachman.
Ie, Our true self or soul is God.

REINCARNATION is a key notion. The idea developed in the 11th thru 9th century BC when the Brahmin priests and the warrior class the Kaishtyra were in a power struggle. The Brahmins doctrine was meant to show that they were superior and that thru the process of re-birth and re-death which was based on the law of KARMA you are born where you are supposed to be.

KARMA is the notion that action will determine what will happen in your next reincarnation. your karma from past lives determines what is happening to you now. The only hope is enough good karma to get out of the cycle of rebirth and redeath called

SAMSARA This is the name of the cycle which will continue until you either break it by gaining knowledge or eliminate all your bad karma. When this happens you reach

MOKSE which means liberation or freedom, salvation, in which one comes to know Brachman, the ultimate reality.--no duality.

there are four characteristics of the experience of Mokse: it intuitive, immediate, self-authenticating and self satisfying

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BHAKTI MOVEMENTS

The bhakti or devotional religions of India are what I will stress now for these are the religions of about 90% of Indians today.

The term Bhakti is translated as devotion, but includes faith, love, surrender and devotional attachment to god.

this devotion is expressed in PUJA, which means adoration or worship on the theoretical level, or offering of fruit or flowers to the deity on the concrete level.

both terms imply a personal relationship and an attitude of reverence and dependence. Bhakti is higher than external

and. The true self is always attached to Krishna and thru meditation and devotion one can come to know him.

Even Women and untouchables (shudras) could be saved thru devotion to Krishna, that is not be re-born. There have been some thought Indian History that have been considered to be an incarnation of Krishna.

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RAMA BHAKTI

The second and only other great epic of India is the RAMAYANA. which was essentially complete as early as the 4th cent. BC. It has 7 chapters. Two thru six were about Rama the hero but the first and 7th were added about the 2nd cent. BC making Rama an incarnation of Vishnu.

The RAMAYANA centers around how Rama won the hand of Sita in an archery contest but were banished to life in the forest where the demon king Ravana came and carried Sita away in his ariel car.

Rama and his brother sought her w/o success until HANUMAN the brave leader of the monkeys aided them. When sita was recovered her purity was questioned and she went thru several ordeals to prove her innocence. Finally, she called on Mother Earth to swallow her if she was chaste, and she was swallowed.

shrines have been built to Hanuman, Rama and his brother and Rama and Sita, who are seen as the ideal divine couple by their followers.

Tulsi Das, a poet of the 16th century did more to spread worship of Rama than anyone else. He emphasizes Rama's grace towards anyone seeking him.

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VAISNAVAS OR VISHNU BHAKTI

Vishnu was a minor solar deity in the early Vedas but came into prominence between 1000 and 800 BC. By the 4th cent. BC he and Shiva were the most popular deities.

the so called HINDU TRINITY is a western projection. However, it consists of BRAHMA the creator (to whom no temples are dedicated in all of India), VISHNU the preserver and SHIVA the destroyer.

However, those who worship any of these ignore the other two.

SHIVA

Shiva meaning "auspicious" is a nickname for Rudra, a god found in the early Vedas. His meditation high on the slopes of the Himalayan Mt. Kailasa maintains the world. He is also Lord of the animals and Lord of the Dance, who supports the rhythm of the universe.

He is worshipped most often in the form of the linga (a representation of the Male organ). In his shrines, his mount, Nandi the Bull, is seen lying before his lingam.

He has not taken on avatars like Vishnu. He is the guru par exallant whose grace illuminates the intellect when one submits to the teachings of his human gurus.

There are three paths of service, worship and meditation but all are to be animated by bhakti. This makes the soul open to Shiva's grace which makes union with him possible.

Liberation is union with Shiva. Shiva is bliss itself.

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SHAKTI BHAKTI

Goddesses of fertility have been worshipped in India since the beginning of the Neolithic age (agriculture begins) and their cult forms an important part of the non indo-Erupeon background

from the 5th century AD on to the present her worship has flourshed. the 80% of Indians who live in rural areas look to the goddess, no vishnu or shiva, for she is in charge of fertility, disease and pestilence.

She can be either beautiful or bloodthirsty. As KALI she demands animal sacrifice and at times, human sacrifice. she waylays travelers and is the patron saint of robbers.

PHILOSOPHICALLY the great goddess is the active (shakti) power of Shiva, who represents the opposite pole of passiveness, consciousness and rest.

Without his shakti power of action personified in his spouse, a male god is unable to do anything. She is the active principle who creates the world and provides grace and liberation.

KALI is the favorite and is particularly worshipped in Bengal and Calcutta. The British outlawed human sacrifice but had a real struggle to do so. Kali manifests both the powers of destruction and grace. All the pleasures of the world are transient, while only Kali is permanent and can grant happiness. She is usually shown as black because she is the ultimate energy.

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CONCLUSION

The important thing to understand is the very different view of reality these people have. They see life as cyclic, rebirth and death with getting out because of devotion (higher bhakti) or knowledge. Thus, when Christians approach them about believing in Jesus so they can have "eternal life" it is an incredibly negative response.

What is important to understand is their sense of duty or DHARMA and the ethic that goes with it but karma plays a big role meaning that when one sees a person in a bad way, to them they are just living out their karma and to interfere means perhaps giving them more bad karma or even earning it yourself.

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BRAHMANIZATION is a process by which the Brahmin priests tried (and try) to control the theistic sects growing up outside their influence by either indicating that the local deity was really Vishnu under a different name or that he was a avatar, or incarnation of Vishnu.

Vishnu has a traditional list of ten incarnations tho some list over 20. (do these only if time.)

These are:

1. the FISH who saved Manu and his family from a world flood by tying his ship to his horn.

2. the TORTOISE who took this form to retrieve some things lost in the flood, both values and deities.

3. the BOAR stems from a tribal totem. He killed a demon and put the Earth back where it belonged.

4. The MAN-LION -a demon couldn't be killed by man or beast, in sun or dark so he killed him at sunset as a man and beast.

5. the DWARF appeared to a demon as a dwarf. He told him he would take over all the cosmos he could tread in 3 steps. then he turned into a giant and took back all heaven and Earth. He left Dali in control of the infernal regions.

6. RAMA with the Ax . took the form of a Brahmin priest and destroyed the kshatriya because of their arrogance.

7. RAMA of the Ramayana. Vishnu took this form to destroy the demon Ravana (the one who kidnapped Sita)

8. KRISHNA Vishnu took this form to kill the demon Kamsa

9. BUDDHA Vishnu became the Buddha in order to delude the wicked by leading them to deny the Vedas and the efficacy of the sacrifices, thereby assuring their damnation.

10. KALKI the avatar of the future -at the end of the present age of Kali. Kalkin will come, mounted on a white horse. He will judge the wicked, reward the good and set up a new age.

VAISHNAVAS comprise the largest group of Indian devotees, but one has to realize that by far the largest number of these are devotees of Krishna and Rama. These devotees do not think of their God as an incarnation of Vishnu. This is the Brahmins idea